

Ajay Shankar

Senior Product Leader

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DoB: 30-Mar-1980 | Nationality: Indian



Summary

Senior product leader with 20+ years turning **product strategy** into **digital transformation at scale** — governing full-lifecycle product portfolios through complex legacy-to-SaaS (Salesforce) migrations.

B.E. Mechanical Engineering and INSEAD MBA. Combines analytical rigour with business strategy.

Experienced in partner ecosystem integration, AI-native and AI-ready products, and executive stakeholder management.

Track record of **growing** and leading multi-disciplinary **product and technology organisations**, establishing portfolio **governance**, **execution** discipline, **data-driven decision** making, and setting standards for **customer-focused delivery**.

Achievements

- * **Operating Model at Scale:** Led 3-year digital transformation and 5-phase, 18-month rollout across 15 countries and 38 sites, for 100,000+ annual customer journeys
- * **Multi-Disciplinary Organisation Growth:** Grew product and tech organisation from 130 to 325 staff; managed \$1.5mn budget
- * **User Insight & Outcome-Driven Prioritization:** Built ambassador-led user discovery practice; aligned prioritization to org. goals; achieved NPS +183%, OSAT +15%, onboarding time -60%
- * **Hands-On Product Depth:** Migrated legacy data to Cloud-based SaaS platform; built Power BI and CRM Analytics dashboards to drive data-informed decisions; built and launched AI-native app with 70+ live users
- * **Executive Communication & Alignment:** Presented at Salesforce World Tour and annual management summits; secured cross-functional buy-in for real-time inventory tool opening new revenue channel

Experience

Senior Product Manager

EF Education First

Mar 2023 – Mar 2026

Zurich, Switzerland

- * **Strategy into Execution:** Owned the product roadmap for EF Language Abroad's platform serving operations teams, **digitally transforming processes, workflows and systems**, over 3 years, and across 100,000+ annual customer journeys; built the operating rhythm for **product planning and prioritization**.
- * **Revenue-focused Alignment:** Aligned cross-functional value streams (Design, Sales, Engineering, Marketing) to secure **executive team buy-in** and deliver a real-time inventory tool - accessing new revenue channels, and laying the foundation for dynamic pricing.
- * **Execution Strategy:** Developed a 5-phase, 38 locations, 15-country and 18-month product rollout strategy, prioritising product features, selecting rollout locations and power users, **aligning these realities with company goals**.
- * **Hands-on Product Building:** Created and executed SQL scripts for data transformation during migration from legacy to a cloud-based platform; designed, built, shipped an AI-native app for the Football World Cup with 70+ live users.

Product Owner — Operations Systems

EF Education First

Jan 2019 – Mar 2023

Zurich, Switzerland

- * **Stakeholder Management:** Built ambassador programmes and ran **user insight** and discovery cycles; applied outcome-driven **prioritization** aligned to organisational goals; drove NPS +183%, and reduced onboarding time by 60% through evidence-based product decisions.
- * **Communication:** Presented at the Salesforce World Tour, and at annual management summits, running feature pre-views, and building **stakeholder alignment** for upcoming features across Sales, Operations, Design, and Engineering.
- * **Data-informed Product Work:** Owned product data, metrics and reporting, building actionable dashboards to indicate business and process health metrics, and ensuring **decisions** are **driven by trusted data**, resulting in customer onboarding time -60% and efficiency +24%.

Project Manager / Operations Manager / Director — Worldwide IT Support

Jan 2007 – Dec 2018

EF Education First

Bengaluru, India / Zurich, Switzerland

- * **Organisation Building:** Grew the **multi-disciplinary** technology organisation from 130 to 325 professionals; established operating procedures, response and resolution standards, and coaching frameworks across Engineering, Support, and Quality; won “Best Service Department” (user vote) four consecutive years.
- * **Operations & Scale:** Led 40-person team across 190 global locations; managed €1.5mn budget and vendor contracts; sustained 99.9% uptime through disciplined operating model and continuous improvement.

Senior Systems Analyst

Jun 2001 – Nov 2005

Satyam Computer Services Pvt. Ltd.

Chennai / Kuala Lumpur, Malaysia / Redmond, WA, USA

- * **Hands-On Delivery & Stakeholder Management:** Directed build and launch of Malaysia’s first national digital health platform (Ministry of Health, 125+ clinics); managed testing and delivery for Microsoft’s Certified Professional programme; awarded double promotion for performance.

Education

Master of Business Administration

Jan – Dec 2006

INSEAD

Fontainebleau, France

B.E. in Mechanical Engineering

Jun 1997 – Apr 2001

University of Madras

Chennai, India

Technical Skills

User & Discovery: User Insight & Discovery, Ambassador Programmes, Outcome-Driven Prioritisation, NPS, OSAT, A/B Testing, Data-Informed Decision-Making, Adoption Metrics.

Hands-On & Data: SQL & Data Migration Scripts, Power BI, CRM Analytics, Agile (CSPO), Jira, Confluence, AI-Native Product Building (Claude, Cursor).

Platform & Scale: Global Multi-Market Rollouts, Localisation, Consumer App Development, Salesforce Experience / Sales / Service Cloud, Data Models & Integration, Scalability, Go-to-Market.

Business & Leadership Skills

Product Leadership: Operating Model Design, Product Strategy and Execution, Multi-Quarter Roadmap, Prioritisation, Sequencing, Product Operations, Product Organisation Building.

Multi-Disciplinary Leadership: Product, Design, UX & Localisation, Cross-Functional Alignment, Stakeholder Management, Executive Communication, People Management, Coaching & Career Pathways.

Languages

* **English** (Native, fluent in both written and spoken) * **German** (B1 / working proficiency) * **French** (A1)

Certifications

* Certified Scrum Product Owner (CSPO)

Scrum Alliance

2025 – 2028

* Vibe Coding with Cursor AI / Vibe Coding with Claude Code

Coursera

2026